

port cities of Bombay and Calcutta would be the first to be linked by rail. In Bombay, even though there were multiple interested groups, it was John Chapman, whose company, the Great Indian Peninsula Railway (GIPR) pressed the Government to back the project. In Calcutta, English engineer Rowland Macdonald Stephenson piloted the project through his company, the East Indian Railway (EIR).

On the western shores

By the mid-1840s, railway mania had sufficiently captured western India. The first local attempts were made in 1844 by British officials of the Bombay government and local merchants whose company, the Bombay Great Eastern Railway, found favour with Sir George Arthur, the Governor-in-Council of Bombay. However, official examinations showed that their proposals lacked concrete surveys. The company was ultimately dissolved, as, despite Arthur's backing, it drew criticism from some government officials, who were against, not only the introduction of railways in the country, but also the idea of any company based in India (as opposed to London) to engage in a venture with capital from Britain.

In 1844, Chapman, who wrote extensively on commerce and trade, proposed a railway line from Bombay to Coringa in the south, under the name Great Indian Railway. Like many proposals before this, it failed to gather support from the East India Company (EIC). However, Chapman's effort found support in politician John Stuart Wortley, who became the Chairman of the Great Indian Railway. It was renamed the Great Indian Peninsula Railway, and was backed and managed by a group of highly motivated and connected individuals.